

Quick take



Dr S Srinivasan, research scientist from C-DAC, holds a doctorate in physics with about 30 years experience in research, teaching (at the UG & PG levels in engineering), information management, software processes and quality management. With some good funding and time on hand, he would like to develop e-learning kiosks, and some packages for tiny and small-scale industries. Overall, he is optimistic about the various developments in open source. Here's what we spoke of over a short tête-à-tête.

Q What kind of projects are you and your team (AU-KBC) working on currently? Is there something that you would like to highlight about your work as a project scientist at C-DAC?

At AU-KBC, the primary focus is on FOSS in higher education—the introduction of FOSS courses in the curriculum, the migration to FOSS in engineering labs, student projects and training of staff/students, the use of FOSS tools for various development activities at AU-KBC (Bioinfotracker, Linux Biopuppy, Morphological Analyser, Security Bed, Wi-Fi related packages, etc), a short course on 'Wi-Fi with FOSS', implementation of FOSS packages like Scilab, Koha, QCad, Talend, etc.

And at C-DAC, the primary focus is the desktop and server versions of Bharat Operating System Solutions (BOSS), which is a GNU/Linux distro based on Debian—and on adding applications to run on BOSS.

Q What, according to you, are the biggest challenges for engineers/developers who are trying to use

OSS for their work?

Awareness and acceptance is the main factor. Most developers seem to have a negative mindset due to either inertia, a fear of the unknown or a misconception that zero or low cost means 'cheap' and, hence, a lack of quality. One needs to have a positive outlook.

Q So if you had to advise someone starting a new open source project, what would you say?

Try to enhance the features of an existing project or adapt/customise a FOSS package to suit local needs (with limited features to start with).

Q How has C-DAC progressed in dealing with open source projects and giving back to the community? Could you list the various initiatives and success stories?

We are interacting with various state government agencies to implement BOSS and help run e-governance and other applications. Besides, we are providing training to personnel from government departments, agencies like the Navy, ELCOT, etc. Other than that, we also provide maintenance and implementation support through a helpdesk and other interactive means. The progress is steady, though we are just scratching the surface.

Q Finally, what has your experience been like at NCOSS-09?

I feel positive, as there is an increasing awareness within the community and a desire to know more. Overall, it has been instructive learning with respect to how industry is adopting FOSS tools. Many companies are now in a position to contribute as mentors.

Later in the day, there was a demo-cum-presentation on Esvaasthya—an open source MIS for Indian hospitals. Another interesting topic was 'Self-Help MIS—Enabling Financial Inclusion: Door Step Financial Services in Rural Areas'. The speaker was of the opinion that, "...market forces are tilting towards open standards and there is an increasing demand from customers towards interoperability."

Finally, at the close of the conference, there was a panel discussion on 'Circumventing barriers to FOSS adoption', which offered an insight into how the OSS community is gearing up for a better and brighter future. Shuvam Misra, along with Ghanshyam Bansal from NIC, Venkatesh Hariharan (Venky) from Red Hat, Shrikant Mullik from L&T

Infotech, and Dr Sasikumar, participated in this discussion.

Content management, collaboration technologies, e-governance, localisation—these were the keywords on everyone's lips. The idea was to educate people on what OSS is all about and to urge them to think beyond GNU/Linux. All said and done, NCOSS-09 certainly achieved what it had aimed to, and did so with top honours. See you at the next conference. **END** 🐧

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